inhabited by lawless herdsmen. Po-me, with its fertile soil, cultivated wheat and pepper, had a flourishing trade in ponies and was noted for its manufacture of blankets, baskets, silver and iron work. This prosperity was due mainly to a number of Chinese soldiers who, on their way to join in the Nepal campaign in 1792, came across this independent country where the writ of neither Lhasa nor Peking held sway. Many of them settled there, married the local women and raised their families.

Finally, lying even further east of Po-yul is the Za-yul region that is Mishmi country. While Tawang was the westernmost trade route between Tibet and Assam, the middle route lay along the Tsangpo (known as the Siang once it crossed the alignment of the watershed on either flank). The Za-yul Chu (Lohit River) afforded the third trade route. The Mishmi were not as warlike as their Abor neighbours to their immediate west. A flourishing barter trade existed with Assam, with the Mishmi acting as the middlemen south of the watershed, and the Popa playing a similar role to the north.

The Chinese, having driven out the Gorkhas, withdrew from Tibet, leaving only two small garrisons at Xigatse and Dingri to keep watch on the Nepalese. They did, however, insist on certain administrative reforms that resulted in the amban being elevated to equal political authority with the Dalai Lama.

General Fu Kangan who had led the Chinese army into Tibet reminded the Dalai Lama in a strongly worded letter of why he needed to be grateful to the Chinese emperor and warned that '[i]f he persists in his old ways of doing things, His Majesty will call back the resident officials and evacuate the Tibetan garrison immediately after the withdrawal of the expeditionary army, and the Court will not come to the help of the Tibet…'

In the immediate aftermath of the Nepalese War, the amban were at their most powerful, yet they made no effort to absorb Tibet into China as a province or in any other manner. Tibet continued to maintain its own language, officials and legal system, and paid no taxes or tribute to China. On the contrary, as pointed out by Melvyn Goldstein in his book, *The Snow Lion and the Dragon*: 'In fact the 1792 reforms included the creation of Tibet's first standing army, the emperor's aim being to enable Tibet to defend itself and thus avoid having to send troops again.'

Meanwhile, the Qing Dynasty faced serious threats from the British in the nineteenth century. Extremely cautious in its dealing with western